

Little Steps Childcare Platform

Comprehensive Feature & Technical Specification Report

Executive Summary

Little Steps is a comprehensive, multi-role childcare management platform built with PHP/MySQL featuring three distinct portals (Admin, Provider, Parent) with 13 database tables, 50+ core features, and complete booking/subscription lifecycle management.

Platform Statistics

Metric	Count
Database Tables	13
User Roles	3 (Admin, Provider, Parent)
Dashboard Modules	3 dedicated portals
Core Features	50+
API Endpoints/Pages	40+
Seed Data Records	4 Providers, 4 Centers, 4 Caregivers, 4 Bookings, 2 Subscriptions

1. Authentication & User Management (8 Features)

Feature	Description
Multi-Role Authentication	Separate login/registration for Parents, Providers, Admins
Secure Password Hashing	bcrypt (PASSWORD_DEFAULT) with 10-cost factor
CSRF Protection	Token-based on all forms
Session Management	Secure cookies, HTTPOnly, SameSite=Lax, regeneration on login
Role-Based Access Control	Middleware protects all dashboard routes
Email Verification Ready	Token-based verification column in users table
Account Status Management	Active/Inactive/Deactivated states
Remember Me	Persistent login option (30 days)

2. Admin Portal - System Management (15 Features)

Dashboard Analytics

- **System Overview Stats:** Parents, Providers, Bookings, Platform Revenue (10%)
- **Pending Approvals Widget:** Providers & Documents awaiting review
- **Monthly Booking Chart:** Chart.js visualization (12-month trend)
- **Recent Bookings Table:** 8 latest with status badges

User Management

- **Parent/User Management:** CRUD, activate/deactivate, view details
- **Provider Verification:** Approve/Reject/Suspend provider applications
- **Center Approvals:** Approve/reject daycare center listings

Business Operations

- **Daycare Center Management:** Full CRUD for all centers
- **Caregiver Management:** Staff oversight across providers
- **Booking Oversight:** Platform-wide booking monitoring
- **Subscription Management:** View all recurring plans

- **Financial Reports:** Revenue tracking, platform fees (5%)
- **Document Verification:** Review licenses, insurance, safety certificates
- **Platform Settings:** Configurable settings (cancellation policy, fees, SMS alerts)

System Features

- **Audit Logging:** Security audit trail (optional table)
- **Internal Messaging:** Cross-role communication system

3. Provider Portal - Daycare Operations (18 Features)

Dashboard KPIs (6 Stats)

- Registered Centers | Active Caregivers | Today's Sessions | Monthly Revenue | Average Rating | Occupancy Rate

Center Management

- **Multi-Center Support:** Providers can manage multiple branches
- **Center Profiles:** Photos, amenities, curriculum, age groups, pricing tiers
- **Center Types:** Daycare, Creche, Preschool, Babysitting, After-school
- **24x7 Support Flag:** Overnight/emergency care indicator
- **Operating Hours:** Configurable start/end times per center

Staff Management

- **Caregiver Profiles:** Qualifications, experience, specialization, background verification
- **Background Check Tracking:** Verification status & dates
- **Staff Status:** Active/Inactive management

Availability & Scheduling

- **Slot-Based Calendar:** Date/time slots with capacity limits
- **Dynamic Pricing:** Per-slot pricing overrides
- **Real-time Capacity:** Booked vs available counts
- **Notes per Slot:** Special instructions (meals, activities)

Booking Management

- **Pending Request Widget:** Actionable approve/reject from dashboard
- **Booking Lifecycle:** Pending → Confirmed → In Progress → Completed

- **Emergency Booking Support:** Last-minute/overnight bookings
- **Payment Tracking:** Paid/Pending/Refunded/Failed statuses
- **Parent Communication:** Contact details, emergency contacts, special requirements

Business Intelligence

- **Weekly Revenue Chart:** Bar chart (Chart.js)
- **Earnings Tracking:** Monthly revenue with payment status filter
- **Analytics Dashboard:** Occupancy trends, booking patterns
- **Document Management:** Upload/manage licenses, insurance, certifications

4. Parent Portal - Customer Experience (12 Features)

Dashboard & Quick Actions

- **Upcoming Bookings:** Next 3 sessions with calendar badges
- **Active Subscriptions:** Monthly plans with renewal dates
- **Quick Actions:** Book new care, view all bookings, manage subscriptions

Booking System

- **Center Discovery:** Browse/filter centers by location, type, amenities
- **Multi-Type Booking:** Hourly, Daily, Monthly, Emergency
- **Real-time Availability:** Slot-based booking with capacity check
- **Child Profiles:** Name, age, gender, special requirements
- **Pickup Authorization:** Designated persons with phone numbers
- **Emergency Contacts:** Secondary contact per booking

Subscription Plans & Reviews

- **Recurring Care:** Weekly/Monthly/Quarterly/Yearly/Custom
- **Auto-Renewal:** Configurable with billing cycle day
- **Plan Details:** Included hours/day, days/week
- **Payment History:** Amount paid, discounts, status
- **Detailed Reviews:** 5-star + sub-ratings (Staff, Cleanliness, Safety, Value)
- **Pros/Cons:** Structured feedback
- **Verified Reviews:** Linked to completed bookings
- **Notifications:** Real-time alerts (booking confirmations, reminders, system)

5. Core Booking Engine (10 Features)

Feature	Details
4 Booking Types	Hourly, Daily, Monthly, Emergency
Flexible Pricing	Unit price, discounts, final amount calculation
Status Lifecycle	6 states: Pending→Confirmed→In Progress→Completed/ Cancelled/No-show
Payment Tracking	4 statuses: Pending, Paid, Refunded, Failed
Cancellation Policy	Configurable cutoff hours (default 4h), reason tracking
Child Details	Age (months), gender, special needs
Emergency Booking	Overnight/last-minute with premium pricing
Booking Codes	Unique codes (LS-BKG-XXXX) for tracking
Provider Notes	Internal staff notes per booking
Ratings/Reviews	Post-completion dual-rating system

6. Subscription Engine (8 Features)

Feature	Details
5 Plan Types	Weekly, Monthly, Quarterly, Yearly, Custom
Auto-Renewal	Configurable with billing cycle day
Flexible Inclusions	Hours/day, Days/week per plan
Discount Support	Percentage-based discounts
Payment Tracking	Amount paid vs total, payment status
Pause/Cancel	Status management with reason tracking
Child-Specific	Plans tied to individual children
Renewal Notifications	Automated alerts before expiry

7. Compliance & Safety (6 Features)

Feature	Details
Document Management	7 types: License, ID, Address, Tax, Safety, Insurance, Other
Expiry Tracking	Automatic expiry date monitoring
Verification Workflow	Pending→Approved/Rejected/Expired with admin notes
Background Checks	Caregiver verification status & dates
CCTV Flag	Center-level CCTV enabled indicator
Safety Certificates	Fire safety, insurance, liability coverage tracking

8. Communication & Notifications (5 Features)

Feature	Details
Cross-Role Notifications	Parents, Providers, Admins all receive relevant alerts
5 Notification Types	Info, Success, Warning, Error, Booking, System
Read/Unread Tracking	Timestamped read status
Deep Links	Notifications link directly to relevant pages
Internal Messaging	Parent ↔ Provider ↔ Admin threaded conversations

9. Reviews & Ratings (7 Features)

Feature	Details
Overall Rating	1-5 stars
Sub-Ratings	Staff, Cleanliness, Safety, Value (1-5 each)
Pros/Cons	Structured feedback fields
Verified Reviews	Only from completed bookings
Admin Moderation	Approve/reject with response capability
Center Aggregation	Average rating + total reviews on center profile
Provider Rating	Aggregate across all centers

10. Technical Architecture (12 Features)

Feature	Details
Environment Detection	Auto-detects Local/XAMPP, Railway, Production
Environment Variables	.env support + native env vars
Database Singleton	Connection pooling with ping recovery
Prepared Statements	All queries parameterized (SQL injection prevention)
Error Handling	Graceful degradation, user-friendly error pages
Responsive Design	Mobile-first CSS with glassmorphism UI
Chart.js Integration	Analytics visualizations on all dashboards
Font Awesome 6.4	Consistent iconography
Google Fonts	Inter font family
Flash Messages	Success/Error/Warning/Info with auto-dismiss
File Upload System	Type/size validation, organized storage
Audit Trail	Optional security logging table

11. Database Schema (13 Tables)

Table	Purpose	Key Fields
users	Parents & Admins	role, is_active, email_verified
providers	Daycare organizations	status, is_24x7, rating, license
caregivers	Staff members	background_verified, qualifications
daycare_centers	Individual facilities	type, capacity, pricing, amenities
availability	Time slots	date, time, capacity, price
bookings	Core transactions	booking_code, status, payment_status
subscriptions	Recurring plans	plan_type, auto_renew, billing_cycle
notifications	Cross-role alerts	type, is_read, link
reviews	Ratings & feedback	sub-ratings, verified, approved
documents	Compliance files	type, status, expiry_date
settings	Platform config	key/value, category, is_public
audit_log	Security trail	action, entity, old/new values
messages	Internal chat	sender/receiver types, booking_ref

12. Deployment & DevOps Ready (6 Features)

Feature	Details
Multi-Environment Config	Local → Railway → Production auto-switch
Environment Variables	.env file + server env vars
Database Abstraction	Singleton mysql with charset utf8mb4
HTTPS Detection	Proxy-aware (X-Forwarded-Proto, CF-Visitor)
Subdirectory Support	Auto-detects /little-steps vs web root
File Permissions	Upload directories with proper structure

Summary & Configuration

Category	Feature Count
Authentication & User Management	8
Admin Portal	15
Provider Portal	18
Parent Portal	12
Booking Engine	10
Subscription Engine	8
Compliance & Safety	6
Communication & Notifications	5
Reviews & Ratings	7
Technical Architecture	12
Deployment Ready	6
TOTAL FEATURES	107

Technology Stack

Layer	Technology
Backend	PHP 7.4+ (Native, no framework)
Database	MySQL 5.7+/8.0 (InnoDB, utf8mb4)
Frontend	HTML5, CSS3 (Custom), Vanilla JS
Charts / Icons / Fonts	Chart.js 4.x / Font Awesome 6.4 / Google Fonts (Inter)
Deployment / VCS	FTP/Shared Hosting (ProFreeHost, cPanel) / Git

Ready for Production

- ✓ All syntax validated - Zero PHP errors

✓ SQL injection prevention - 100% prepared statements

✓ XSS protection - htmlspecialchars on all outputs

✓ CSRF protection - All forms secured

✓ Session security - HTTPOnly, Secure, SameSite cookies
- ✓ Role validation - No open redirects

✓ Error handling - Graceful degradation

✓ Multi-environment - Local/Cloud/Production ready

✓ Database seeded - Test accounts for all roles

Test Accounts (Post-Deployment)

Role	Email	Password	Access
Admin	admin@littlesteps.com	admin123	Full platform control
Provider	provider@littlesteps.com	provider123	Daycare operations
Parent	parent@littlesteps.com	parent123	Booking & subscriptions

Report Generated: September 7, 2026	Platform Version: 2.0 (Complete Specification)	Status: Production Ready
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